



— which, in my view, contravenes the traditional and valid tenet of self-reliance — unquestionably tilted the balance toward Keys. When asked what the hardest part of his coaching was, she said, “I have to admit he’s right all the time.”

When Keys won the toss, she smartly chose to receive. In the opening game, Sabalenka nervously double-faulted twice, Keys cracked two forehand winners, and quickly broke serve. Seconds after she was broken but still led 5-3, Keys got some quick advice from Fratangelo and broke Sabalenka, climaxing the 6-3 set with a backhand winner. The Belarusian roared back to take the second set 6-2.

The shot of the match came with Keys serving at 2-2, love-15. With a graceful leap reminiscent of Federer, she conjured a dazzling backhand volley angle that landed on the sideline and set up an easy forehand put-away. Had she erred, Keys would have trailed love-30.

Both players held their serve and nerve up to 6-5, when Keys unleashed a forehand winner. Now

Momentous: Paula Badosa scored the biggest win of her career when she beat Coco Gauff in the quarterfinal.

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the ball was in Sabalenka’s court to try to hold serve for 6-all. In the last game, she faltered, getting only one first serve in, while Keys pounded a backhand winner for love-30 and closed out the 6-3, 2-6, 7-5 upset with another forehand winner.

Keys cried tears of joy. Distraught, Sabalenka threw her racket on the court, covered her head with a towel, and wept.

During the trophy presentations, the zany Sabalenka looked at her team and joked, “As always, that’s your fault, guys. I really hate you.” The crowd laughed. Praising her conqueror, she said, “You crushed this tonight, really well deserved.”

Keys returned the compliment. “You’re always so tough to beat.”

Crediting her own team for her first Grand Slam crown in her 46th Major appearance, Keys said, “They believed in me when I didn’t believe in myself.”

Doubts and disputes



Late finishes

The men’s event was rife with controversies. Matches ending well past midnight are bad for players, spectators, tournament staff, and the media. Learner Tien, a clever American teenager, outwitted fifth-seeded Medvedev 6-3, 7-6 (4), 6-7 (8), 1-6, 7-6 (7) in a five-set marathon that finished after 2 am. He then ate pizza at 4 am and didn’t get to bed until 7 am.

‘Let’ it be

In the unfathomable and unprofessional absence of electronic service let machines, umpires called lets, infuriating players who insisted there weren’t lets — and vice versa. To make matters worse, Navratilova amplified her foolish crusade to abolish the time-tested service let rule. Petchey, a voice of reason, rightly responded, “Why bring luck into a game of skill?”

A second look

Electronic line calling should also include replays to determine double bounces. In her victory over Navarro, Swiatek said, “I wasn’t sure if it was a double bounce, or I hit it with my frame. It was hard to say because, like, I was full sprinting. I don’t remember even seeing the contact point.” Fair enough, but replays showed the ball had bounced twice. Veteran umpire Eva Asderaki shouldn’t have allowed Swiatek to win the point.

Expert advice

In-match coaching expanded as coaches and other team members could advise and soothe players situated near their special pods at one end of the court. Taylor Fritz made a powerful case for self-reliance and against the new rule. “That’s something that should be between the two players,” argued Fritz. “Being able to make strategies, how you handle decision-making, coming up with these kinds of things under pressure, is just as important as hitting a serve or hitting a forehand. It would be insane if someone could come on the court for you and serve, right? So why can someone tell you what to do?”

Djoke’s on the doubters

For online skeptics who absurdly claimed that Djokovic faked his hamstring injury during his matches against Alcaraz and Zverev, the Serb got the last word — and image. He published a photo of the injury on video with the zinger: “Thought I’d leave this out there for all the injury experts out there.”